EXTRACTS FROM REVIEWS

Pro bono publico

Peter Medawar in The Spectator, *15 January 1977*

When confronted by what is ostensibly altruistic or anyhow non-selfish behaviour in animals, amateurs of biology, a class that includes an increasing number of sociologists, are very easily tempted to say that it has evolved 'for the benefit of the species.'

There is a well known myth, for example, that lemmings–evidently more conscious of the need for it than we are—regulate population size by plunging over cliffs by the thousand to perish in the sea. Surely even the most gullible naturalist must have asked himself how such altruism could have become part of the behavioural repertoire of the species, having regard to the fact that the genetic make-ups conducive to it must have perished with their possessors in this grand demographic auto-da-fe. To dismiss this as a myth is not to deny, however, that genetically selfish actions may sometimes 'present' (as clinicians say) as disinterested or altruistic actions. Genetic factors conducive to grandmotherly indulgence, as opposed to callous indifference, may prevail in evolution because kindly grandmothers are selfishly promoting the survival and propagation of the fraction of their own genes that are present in their grandchildren.

Richard Dawkins, one of the most brilliant of the rising generation of biologists, gently and expertly debunks some of the favourite illusions of social biology about the evolution of altruism, but this is on no account to be thought of as a debunking kind of book: it is, on the contrary, a most skilful reformulation of the central problems of social biology in terms of the genetical theory of natural selection. Beyond this, it is learned, witty and very well written. One of the things that attracted Richard Dawkins to the study of zoology was the 'general likeableness' of animals—a point of view shared by all good biologists that shines throughout this book.

Although *The Selfish Gene* is not disputative in character, it was a very necessary part of Dawkins's programme to deflate the pretensions of such books as Lorenz's *On Aggression*, Ardrey's *The Social Contract*, and Eibl-Eibesfeldt's *Love and Hate*: 'the trouble with these books is that their authors got it totally and utterly wrong … because they misunderstood how evolution works. They made the erroneous assumption that the important thing in evolution is the good of the species (or the group) rather than the good of the individual (or the gene).'

There is indeed truth enough for a dozen sermons in the schoolboy aphorism that 'a chicken is the egg's way of making another egg.' Richard Dawkins puts it thus:

> The argument of this book is that we, and all other animals, are machines created by our genes … I shall argue that a predominant quality to be expected in a successful gene is ruthless selfishness. This gene selfishness will usually give rise to selfishness in individual behaviour. However, as we shall see, there are special circumstances in which a gene can achieve its own selfish goals best by fostering a limited form of altruism at the level of individual animals. 'Special' and 'limited' are important words in the last